

# **Report on YouTube Ownership**

## **Introduction**

YouTube stands as a dominant force in online video sharing, boasting billions of users and shaping how individuals consume and share content. Understanding the ownership structure of this massive platform is crucial for grasping its strategic direction and overall influence. This report aims to provide an in-depth analysis of YouTube's ownership, tracing its history to its current standing as a subsidiary of Google, itself a part of the Alphabet Inc. conglomerate. By examining the roles of key stakeholders, including founders, parent companies, and major shareholders, this report will offer a comprehensive view of YouTube's control and governance.

## **YouTube's Founding and Early Years**

YouTube was founded on February 14, 2005, by Chad Hurley, Steve Chen, and Jawed Karim, all former employees of PayPal ([Wikipedia](#)). The platform was established in San Bruno, California, and quickly gained popularity as a user-friendly space for uploading, viewing, and sharing videos ([Wikipedia](#)). The core concept behind YouTube was to allow anyone to operate a personal broadcasting station, signified by the slogan "Broadcast Yourself" and the use of "Channels" for user profiles ([Wikipedia](#)).

## **Acquisition by Google**

On November 13, 2006, Google acquired YouTube for US\$1.65 billion, equivalent to \$2.39 billion in 2024 ([Wikipedia](#)). This acquisition marked a significant turning point for YouTube, providing access to Google's vast resources, technology, and expertise. Google's infrastructure and algorithms helped improve the user experience on YouTube, introducing features such as recommended videos and personalized playlists, which enhanced engagement and drew more users to the platform ([Business Model Analyst](#)).

Google also expanded YouTube's business model, shifting from relying solely on advertising revenue to offering paid content such as movies and exclusive content. The introduction of YouTube Premium provided users with a subscription option for ad-free viewing ([Wikipedia](#)).

## **YouTube Under Alphabet Inc.**

In 2015, Google underwent a corporate restructuring, resulting in the creation of Alphabet Inc., a multinational conglomerate ([Business Model Analyst](#)). This restructuring was initiated by Google's co-founders, Larry Page and Sergey Brin, to allow for greater autonomy in their diverse business ventures, separating Google's core internet business from other innovative projects ([Business Model Analyst](#)).

As a wholly-owned subsidiary of Google, YouTube is part of Alphabet Inc. Alphabet has complete ownership and control of YouTube's operations, finances, and strategic decisions ([Business Model Analyst](#)). Alphabet's overarching objective is to manage and expand its diverse portfolio of businesses, of which YouTube is a significant component ([Business Model Analyst](#)).

## **Key Individuals and Shareholders**

While YouTube is owned by Google, and Google by Alphabet, significant control resides with key individual shareholders, particularly Google's co-founders, Larry Page and Sergey Brin ([Surgegraph](#)). Page and Brin maintain substantial holdings of Class B shares, which grant them super-voting rights, allowing them to collectively command a significant percentage of the voting power ([Surgegraph](#)). This concentrated control enables them to influence key corporate decisions and policies ([Surgegraph](#)).

As of December 2022, Sergey Brin owned 5.7% of Alphabet's shares but controlled 24.9% of all votes due to his ownership of super-voting shares ([Kamil Franek](#)). The market value of Sergey Brin's stake in Alphabet was \$65.4 billion ([Kamil Franek](#)).

Other notable shareholders include institutional investors such as Vanguard Group and BlackRock, which are among the largest shareholders ([Surgegraph](#)). These institutional investors, while holding significant stakes, are generally considered "passive" investors, meaning they typically do not exert direct control over the company's operations ([Surgegraph](#)).

## **YouTube Leadership**

Since its founding in 2005, YouTube has been led by a series of CEOs. Chad Hurley was the first CEO, leading the company until 2010 ([Wikipedia](#)). After Google's acquisition, Salar Kamangar took over as CEO, holding the position until 2014 ([Wikipedia](#)). Susan Wojcicki then became CEO, resigning in 2023 and taking on an advisory role for Google and Alphabet ([Wikipedia](#)). In a sad turn of events, Wojcicki passed away on August 9, 2024, after battling non-small-cell lung cancer ([Wikipedia](#)).

The current CEO of YouTube is Neal Mohan, who was appointed on February 16, 2023 ([Wikipedia](#)).

## **Recent Developments and Challenges**

In recent years, YouTube has faced various challenges and implemented significant changes. In 2022, YouTube experimented with showing users a long chain of short, unskippable adverts at the beginning of longer videos, intending to consolidate all ads ([Wikipedia](#)). This experiment was met with public outrage and was subsequently ended on September 19 of that year ([Wikipedia](#)).

In October 2022, YouTube announced the rollout of customizable user handles in addition to channel names, which would also become channel URLs ([Wikipedia](#)).

In late October 2023, YouTube began cracking down on the use of ad blockers on the platform, displaying pop-up warnings to users and inviting them to subscribe to YouTube Premium ([Wikipedia](#)). YouTube asserts that the use of ad blockers violates its terms of service ([Wikipedia](#)).

## **Google's Broader Portfolio and Acquisitions**

YouTube is just one of many companies owned by Google. Google and Alphabet collectively own over 200 companies ([Hatchwise](#)). Some of the notable companies owned by Google include:

- Adsense
- Android
- DoubleClick
- Google Chrome
- Google Drive

- Google Maps
- Google Play
- Google Fiber
- Nest
- Waze
- Fitbit
- DeepMind
- Waymo
- Google Pixel
- Calico

Google's acquisition strategy has been a significant factor in its growth and expansion.

## **Conclusion**

In conclusion, YouTube is owned by Google, which is a subsidiary of Alphabet Inc. Alphabet Inc., created in 2015 by Larry Page and Sergey Brin, serves as the parent company, overseeing YouTube's operations, finances, and strategic decisions. While Google and Alphabet have formal ownership, key individuals, especially Larry Page and Sergey Brin, wield substantial control through their ownership of super-voting Class B shares. This structure allows for long-term strategic planning and investments, fostering YouTube's continued growth and innovation. This complex structure enables YouTube to operate with the resources and expertise of a large corporation while still maintaining its own identity and fostering a vibrant community of creators and viewers. Despite recent challenges, such as controversies over advertising strategies and ad blocker crackdowns, YouTube remains a dominant force in the digital landscape, thanks to its robust ownership and strategic leadership.

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